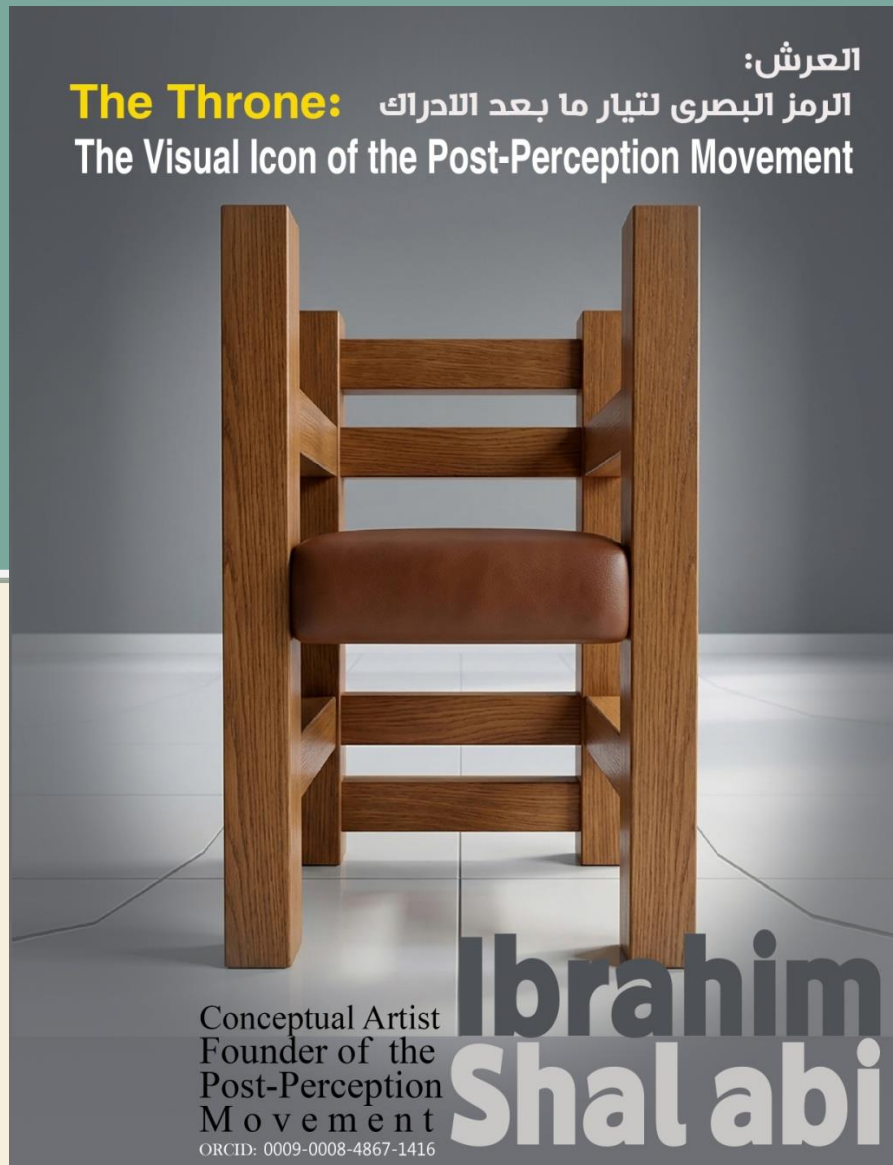


Why Your Senses Are Lying to You (And How Art Can Help)



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Introduction: The Day Reality Cracked

I remember the exact moment I stopped trusting my eyes completely. It was not in an art gallery or a philosophy lecture. It was in my small studio in Kafr El-Sheikh, staring at a computer screen, watching a video of a person who did not exist.

The face on the screen was perfectly human. It blinked. It smiled. It turned its head from side to side. The skin had pores. The eyes had reflections. The hair moved naturally. Everything about the face said: "I am a real person. I have a name. I have a history. I exist."

But the face was generated entirely by artificial intelligence. No camera had ever captured it. No light had ever touched it. No mother had ever given it birth. It was a mathematical pattern – nothing more – rendered so perfectly that my eyes could not tell the difference between this non-person and the millions of real faces I had seen in my life.

I sat in silence for a long time. Then I wrote a single sentence in my notebook: *"Seeing is no longer believing. What do we do now?"*

That question became the engine of everything I have made since. This article is an attempt to answer it – not with philosophy, but with simple explanations of how your senses are being exploited, and how art can help you defend them.

Part One: Your Eyes Are Not Cameras

Most people believe that seeing works like photography. Light enters the eye. The lens focuses it. An image forms on the retina. The brain reads that image like a photograph. Seeing equals recording.

This is completely wrong.

Your eyes are not cameras. They are not passive recorders of reality. They are active, hungry, constantly guessing organs that take shortcuts constantly. They do not see everything. They see what they expect to see.

Here is a simple test you can do right now. Look at the room around you. Your eyes tell you that you see the entire room in sharp detail. But you do not. You see only a tiny spot in the center of your vision – about the size of your thumb at arm's length. Everything else is blurry, incomplete, filled in by your brain's guesses.

Your brain is not lazy. It is efficient. It does not waste energy processing information that is probably not important. It predicts what you are likely to see based on past experience, and it shows you that prediction instead of the actual data.

Most of the time, this works perfectly. Your brain predicts correctly. You navigate the world without noticing the gaps.

But here is the danger: your brain's predictions can be manipulated. If someone knows what you expect to see, they can show you exactly that – even if it does not exist.

This is how magic tricks work. This is how optical illusions work. And this is how deepfakes work. Artificial intelligence systems have learned to predict what your eye expects to see so perfectly that they can generate images and videos that your brain accepts as real without question.

Your eyes are not lying to you because they are broken. They are lying to you because they are doing exactly what they evolved to do: take shortcuts, make predictions, and show you what is probably there. The problem is that in the digital age, "what is probably there" can be manufactured from nothing.

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art Two: Your Ears Are Not Recorders Either

The same principle applies to hearing. Your ears do not record sound like a microphone. They sample, they guess, and they fill in the gaps.

Have you ever misheard song lyrics? You sing along confidently, convinced you know the words. Then you read the actual lyrics and realize you have been singing nonsense for years. Your ears did not fail you. Your brain predicted what it expected to hear, and it showed you that prediction as if it were real.

In my work "Beyond Sound," I exploit this tendency directly. I placed ordinary household appliances – a blender, an iron, a fan, a hair dryer – in a gallery space. Each appliance was connected to electricity. Visitors could touch them, turn them on, and hear what they produced.

But the sounds did not match the appliances. The blender produced the sound of ocean waves. The iron produced the sound of human breathing. The fan produced the sound of birds singing. The hair dryer produced the sound of a train passing.

The confusion is immediate and physical. Your hand touches the blender. Your finger presses the button. Your ear expects a loud, mechanical grinding sound. Instead, you hear waves. For a moment, you are lost. Your automatic perception has failed.

What is happening inside your brain? Your auditory system is desperately trying to reconcile two contradictory signals. The visual signal says "blender." The auditory signal says "ocean." Your brain cannot accept both, so it hesitates. In that hesitation, you become

aware of your own perception. You notice that you are hearing. You notice that you are expecting. You notice that your expectations can be wrong.

That moment of noticing is the gift. Most of the time, you move through the world without noticing your own perception. You just hear. You just see. You just believe. But in that moment of contradiction, you wake up.

The problem is that in the digital world, these contradictions are becoming rarer. Artificial intelligence is getting better at giving your ears exactly what they expect to hear – even when the sound has no original source. A cloned voice says exactly what you expect that person to say. A generated sound effect matches exactly what you expect that action to produce.

Your ears are not lying to you because they are broken. They are lying to you because they have been trained to expect certain patterns, and technology has learned to produce those patterns perfectly.

Part Three: Why This Matters More Than Ever

You might be thinking: "So my senses take shortcuts. So what? I have gotten along fine so far."

The difference is scale.

For most of human history, the gap between perception and reality was small. Your eyes might be fooled by a magician on stage once a year. Your ears might mishear a song lyric once a month. These were minor errors, easily corrected, with no lasting consequences.

Today, the gap between perception and reality is being exploited billions of times per second.

Every time you scroll through social media, algorithms are testing your attention. They learn what you expect to see, what you want to see, what you fear to see. Then they show you more of it – not because it is true, but because it keeps you watching.

Every time you watch a video online, you cannot be certain that the person speaking is real. Their face could be generated. Their voice could be cloned. Their words could be fabricated. And the technology is now so advanced that experts cannot tell the difference.

Every time you see a photograph in the news, you cannot be certain that the event it depicts ever happened. Images can be generated from text descriptions. Events can be simulated. Reality can be manufactured on demand.

This is not a future possibility. This is happening now.

The problem is not that technology is evil. The problem is that your senses were not designed for this environment. They evolved in a world where seeing was believing, where hearing was trusting, where the gap between perception and reality was small enough to ignore. That world no longer exists. But your senses have not changed. They are still taking shortcuts. They are still making predictions. They are still showing you what is probably there.

And "what is probably there" can now be generated by algorithms that know your expectations better than you do.

Part Four: How Art Can Help

If the problem is that your senses have been trained to expect certain patterns, the solution is to retrain them. You need to learn new patterns. You need to build new expectations. You need to develop what I call **perceptual immunity**.

This is where art comes in.

Art has always been a training ground for perception. When you look at a painting, you are practicing seeing. When you listen to music, you are practicing hearing. When you watch a film, you are practicing following a narrative with your senses.

But traditional art trains you to perceive traditional things – beauty, harmony, representation, emotion. Post-Perceptual art trains you to perceive the act of perception itself.

Here is how it works.

Step One: Controlled Confusion

In a safe environment – an art gallery, a museum, a public installation – you experience perceptual confusion deliberately designed to disrupt your automatic expectations. A blender that sounds like ocean waves. An image that might be real or might be generated. A choice with no clear right answer.

The confusion is real, but the stakes are low. No one is trying to deceive you for profit. No algorithm is trying to keep you scrolling. You are in a laboratory, not a battlefield.

Step Two: Noticing the Gap

In the moment of confusion, your automatic perception stops. You become aware that you are perceiving. You notice the gap between what you expected and what you experienced. You ask yourself: "Why did I expect that? Where did that expectation come from?"

This act of noticing is the core of perceptual training. Most of the time, you do not notice your expectations. You just have them. But in the controlled confusion of a Post-Perceptual artwork, you cannot avoid noticing. The gap is too wide. The contradiction is too sharp.

Step Three: Building Memory

Each time you notice a gap between expectation and reality, your brain builds memory. It learns: "I expected the blender to sound mechanical, but it sounded like waves. My expectation was wrong. I need to be more careful."

Over time, these memories accumulate. Your perceptual immune system grows stronger. You become faster at recognizing when your expectations are being exploited. You become slower to trust what your senses show you without question.

Step Four: Transfer to Daily Life

The ultimate goal is not to make you a better art viewer. The goal is to make you a more conscious perceiver in daily life. When you scroll through social media, you remember the blender that sounded like waves. You ask: "Is this image real or generated? Is this voice authentic or cloned? Is this event true or fabricated?"

You do not become paranoid. You become careful. You do not stop trusting your senses entirely. You learn to trust them wisely, with awareness of their limitations.

Part Five: Real Examples from My Work

Let me give you three concrete examples of how this training works in practice.

Example One: The AI Pipes

In my work "This is Not a Pipe," viewers sit in a dark room and watch eight images of pipes appear on a large screen. Seven are generated by artificial intelligence. One is a photograph of a real pipe. After the eighth image, a text appears asking: "Which one is real?"

Most viewers cannot tell. Their visual confidence collapses. They realize that their eyes – which they have trusted their entire lives – are not reliable guides in the age of AI.

But here is the important part: the confusion happens in a safe space. No one is trying to trick them for profit. No algorithm is trying to sell them something. They are in an art gallery, prepared for an experiment. The stakes are low.

When they leave the gallery and scroll through social media later that day, they remember the pipes. They ask: "Is this image real? Could it be generated?" The training transfers.

Example Two: The Hanging Table

In my work "The Hanging Table," viewers enter a white room. A large dining table hangs upside down from the ceiling – plates still on it, as if waiting for a meal that never came. Below, twelve short chairs face the empty space where the table should be. You hear wind, rain, and distant thunder.

Nothing is confusing about the individual elements. You see a table. You see chairs. You hear weather sounds. But the combination is deeply unsettling. The table is upside down. The chairs are too short. The meal is expected but never arrives. The promise is visible but unreachable.

The confusion is not visual or auditory. It is existential. You are confused about what you are supposed to feel, what you are supposed to expect, what you are supposed to wait for.

This confusion trains a different kind of perception: the perception of meaning itself. You learn to notice when your expectations are not just sensory but emotional, cultural, and spiritual. You learn to ask: "Why did I expect a resolution? Why did I expect the table to be reachable? Where did that expectation come from?"

Example Three: The Threshold of Beauty

In my work "The Threshold of Beauty," viewers sit in a room filled with the sound of birds singing. The sound begins beautifully – one bird, clear and pure. Then more birds join. Ten. Fifty. A hundred. Five hundred. The sound becomes overwhelming, then chaotic, then painful.

Each viewer has their own threshold – the point at which beauty turns into suffering. Some leave early. Some stay longer. The choice is theirs.

This work trains perceptual immunity in a different way. It teaches you that your own senses have limits. It teaches you to notice when you are approaching those limits. It teaches you to make a choice: stay or leave, endure or protect yourself.

In daily life, you are constantly bombarded with information, images, sounds, and demands for attention. Your perceptual system has limits. But you rarely notice them because the bombardment never stops. "The Threshold of Beauty" gives you a safe space to discover your own limits – and to practice making choices about what you allow into your perception.

Part Six: What You Can Do Right Now

You do not need to visit an art gallery to start building perceptual immunity. Here are five simple exercises you can do today, starting now.

Exercise One: The Image Test

Find a photograph online – any photograph. Ask yourself three questions:

1. Could this image have been generated by artificial intelligence?
2. What evidence do I have that it is real?
3. Would I bet my life on its authenticity?

You do not need to find definitive answers. You just need to practice asking the questions. Over time, asking becomes automatic. Doubt becomes a habit.

Exercise Two: The Sound Test

Close your eyes and listen to the sounds around you. For each sound, ask: "What is its source? Could that source be simulated? Could this sound be generated?"

Again, the goal is not certainty. The goal is practice. You are training your ears to notice that hearing is an interpretation, not a recording.

Exercise Three: The Expectation Log

For one day, keep a small notebook or a note on your phone. Every time you catch yourself expecting something – a sound, a sight, a reaction, a result – write it down. At the end of the day, review your expectations. How many were accurate? How many were wrong? Where did your expectations come from?

Exercise Four: The Contradiction Hunt

For one week, actively look for contradictions between what you see and what you hear. Watch a video with the sound off, then with the sound on. Does the sound match the image? Listen to a podcast without reading the description. Does the voice match what you imagined? Notice how often your senses agree – and how often they only seem to agree because your brain is filling in the gaps.

Exercise Five: The Five-Minute Pause

Before you share any image, video, or news article on social media, pause for five minutes. In those five minutes, ask yourself: "Could this be fake? What evidence do I have? Am I sharing this because it is true, or because it confirms what I already believe?"

Five minutes is not long. But it is long enough for your perceptual immune system to wake up and ask a few questions.

Conclusion: The Gift of Doubt

I began this article with a story about the day I stopped trusting my eyes completely. I watched a video of a person who did not exist, and I realized that seeing was no longer believing.

That realization was frightening. But it was also liberating.

Doubt is not a weakness. It is a strength. It is the beginning of wisdom. It is the foundation of perceptual immunity. It is the skill that protects you from deception, manipulation, and exploitation.

Your senses are lying to you. Not because they are broken, but because they are doing exactly what they evolved to do: taking shortcuts, making predictions, showing you what is probably there. The problem is that in the digital age, "what is probably there" can be manufactured from nothing.

The solution is not to stop trusting your senses entirely. The solution is to trust them wisely – with awareness of their limitations, with habits of doubt, with a perceptual immune system that has been trained to recognize the signs of deception.

Art can help you build that immune system. Not through lectures or warnings, but through direct experience – controlled confusion in a safe environment, followed by noticing, followed by memory, followed by transfer to daily life.

I have spent over thirty years developing these methods. I have tested them in eighteen solo exhibitions and over eighty group exhibitions across Egypt, Spain, Venezuela, Qatar,

Iraq, and Malta. My work has been the subject of a PhD dissertation and has been documented by the Serbian Ministry of Culture. In 2026, my installation "Isolation" was selected for the Egypt Pavilion at the Malta Biennale.

But none of that matters as much as this simple truth: you can start building your perceptual immunity today. You do not need a gallery. You do not need a museum. You do not need a degree in art history or computer science.

You only need the courage to doubt. And the willingness to practice.

Your senses are lying to you. Let art help you learn to see through the lies.

About the Author



Ibrahim Shalaby (b. 1966, Kafr El-Sheikh, Egypt) is a visual artist, researcher, and the founder of the Post-Perception movement. Over three decades, he has developed a distinctive body of work spanning painting, collage, photography, performance, installation, and video art. His work has been selected to represent Egypt at the Malta Biennale 2026, and he has been the subject of a PhD dissertation at Ain Shams University. He is the author of the six-volume "Alban Alwan" series, including the theoretical foundation of Post-Perception.

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